had ever seen.6 Among the privileged guests, Walter Ulbricht could be seen beaming at his young protégé. He was deeply impressed. Summing up his achievement, Erich recounted:

I declared that the youth of our country would never bear arms for imperialist interests and that it would never fight against its liberator, the socialist Soviet Union. In a telegram to J.V. Stalin the delegates of millions of young people confirmed their determination to exert all their might to bring about the banning of the atom bomb, to shirk no effort or exertion in order to thwart the criminal designs of aggressive circles in the West, and never again to permit the German people and its youth to be driven into a war against the Soviet Union, against other socialist countries, or against progress.

[7]

Bowled over by the spectacle, Ulbricht nominated Honecker as a candidate member of the Politburo, the actual government of the GDR. ‘At the age of 38,’ Erich wrote sheepishly, ‘I was the youngest in a collective body of workers.’ From here on, his star was firmly hitched to Ulbricht, who also engineered his protégé’s membership to the Central Committee.

Meanwhile, over at the FDJ, Honecker was busily preparing for the Third World Festival Games of Youth and Students, which drew 2 million youths from 104 nations to East Berlin between 5 and 19 August 1951. Before the event, he described the festival as a chance for German youth to thank Soviet mentors who had both sheltered them from ‘capitalist exploitation and guided them toward socialist solidarity’.8 Wilhelm Pieck set the tone, telling the opening ceremony that ‘British and American warmongers, despite their overwhelming defeat in Korea, have not given up their war